

Draft - expert review pending

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Learning Theories - assessment and review

Unit summary

Behaviourism defines learning as change in observable behaviour, through two mechanisms: classical conditioning, learning by association, which explains what pupils cannot help; and operant conditioning, learning from consequences, where reinforcement (positive or negative) makes behaviour more frequent and punishment makes it less. The discipline is reading consequences for what they actually train.

The cognitive turn defines learning as change in thinking. Piaget gives it structure - schemas adjusted by assimilation and accommodation, with productive confusion as the signature of real rebuilding. Bruner gives it a route - enactive before iconic before symbolic, guided discovery, and the spiral that returns to each idea stronger.

Bandura shows that much learning arrives by observation: attention, retention, reproduction and motivation, with reinforcement often vicarious. Models are chosen by importance, similarity and warmth, and the model's outcome, not the model's words, is what observers read.

Constructivism holds that understanding is built, not delivered - psychologically by the individual, socially with assistance. Vygotsky's zone of proximal development locates the teachable gap; Bruner's scaffolding names the support that must come down. The four families are lenses, not rivals, and the professional act is the evidenced choice.

Summative assessment

Multiple-choice questions (MCQs)

1. Behaviourism defines learning as: (*Remember*) a) a change in what the learner can explain b) a change in observable behaviour c) the construction of understanding with assistance d) the observation of a model's outcome
2. In the corridor scene, the pupils fall silent at the head teacher's footsteps. The footsteps are, in conditioning terms: (*Understand*) a) the unconditioned stimulus b) the response c) the conditioned stimulus d) the reinforcer
3. Negative reinforcement is: (*Understand*) a) punishment by another name b) removing something disliked, which strengthens the behaviour it follows c) adding something disliked, which weakens the behaviour it follows d) the absence of any consequence
4. A star chart raises completed work, and copying also rises. The most precise reading is: (*Apply*) a) the chart has failed b) the chart is reinforcing completion, and copying is the cheapest route to it c) the pupils are cheating and must be punished d) stars have become a conditioned stimulus for copying
5. A pupil calls every four-legged animal "billi". Meeting a dog and separating it from cats is: (*Understand*) a) assimilation b) accommodation c) extinction d) vicarious reinforcement
6. Bruner's three modes of representation, in the order teaching should follow, are: (*Remember*) a) symbolic, iconic, enactive b) enactive, symbolic, iconic c) enactive, iconic, symbolic d) iconic, enactive, symbolic
7. Rashid recites a poem perfectly and cannot say what it is about. The most accurate account is: (*Apply*) a) he has not been reinforced enough b) the words were assimilated into no schema that carried the poem's meaning c) his zone of proximal development is too small d) he lacks the enactive mode of representation
8. A pupil watches a classmate praised for politeness and becomes more polite. This is: (*Understand*) a) classical conditioning b) negative

reinforcement c) vicarious reinforcement d) accommodation

9. Babar finishes four sums with one hint and two alone by Friday. The hint, and its removal, illustrate: (*Apply*) a) the zone of proximal development and scaffolding b) extinction and generalisation c) positive punishment d) the spiral curriculum
10. "Constructivism means the teacher stops teaching." The corrected version is: (*Understand*) a) the teacher teaches less and tests more b) the teacher designs the site, supplies the schemas and removes the scaffold on schedule c) the teacher becomes a peer among learners d) the teacher waits for each pupil's zone to widen on its own

Restricted-response questions (RRQs)

1. Define behaviourism in one sentence and name the two mechanisms it offers, with a classroom example of each. (*Understand*)
2. Label the corridor scene's four conditioning elements in two lines: footsteps, scolding, falling silent, and the repeated pairing. (*Apply*)
3. In two sentences, explain why a promised prize that never arrives is not a consequence, and what it teaches instead. (*Understand*)
4. Give the reinforcement-punishment distinction precisely, with one classroom instance of negative reinforcement that is not punishment. (*Understand*)
5. Explain assimilation and accommodation with one example of your own, in two sentences. (*Understand*)
6. Name Bruner's three modes and place one lesson you know into their order, or name the missing mode. (*Apply*)
7. Explain why Miss Sadia's "good try" spread to pupils she never spoke to, using vicarious reinforcement. (*Apply*)
8. List two things that make a model strong, and say why a teacher cannot decline the office. (*Understand*)
9. Define the zone of proximal development with Babar's three task levels, in three lines. (*Understand*)
10. Give the four-lens reading of Amjad: one sentence per lens, each naming its response. (*Analyze*)

Extended-response questions (ERQs)

1. **The star chart, precisely.** Miss Farzana's chart raised completed work and copying together. Analyse what the chart actually reinforced, redesign it so the trained behaviour is what was intended, and name the risk your redesign carries. (*Analyze*)
2. **Two poems.** Rashid recited perfectly and understood nothing; Sana stumbled and understood. Using the cognitive turn, explain the difference, and argue what each pupil's teacher should do next. (*Analyze*)
3. **The first wrong answer.** Using social learning theory, explain why a teacher's response to the first wrong answer of the year is among the most consequential acts in a classroom, and what a teacher should deliberately make observable instead. (*Analyze*)
4. **Ninety seconds.** Babar's breakthrough came not from a better explanation but from the right help at the right distance. Analyse the episode through social constructivism: where the zone was, what the scaffold was, and why its removal was the point. (*Analyze*)
5. **Four lenses, one pupil.** Amjad completes no written work, watches demonstrations attentively and explains them orally. Read him through all four theory families, choose the lens you would act on first, justify it with evidence, and name what would make you switch. (*Evaluate*)

Answers and marking guidance

MCQ answer key

1. **b** - the behaviourist focus is observable behaviour, by deliberate decision.
2. **c** - the footsteps were neutral until they repeatedly preceded the scolding; then they became conditioned.
3. **b** - negative reinforcement removes something disliked and strengthens the behaviour; it is one of the two strengtheners.
4. **b** - the chart is precise: it reinforces completion, and the cheapest route to completion is copying.
5. **b** - the schema itself changed: accommodation.
6. **c** - do it, see it, then the sign for it.

7. **b** - the recitation was trained (operant) but the words met no meaning-carrying schema.
8. **c** - the reinforcement was watched, not felt: vicarious.
9. **a** - the hint is the scaffold inside the zone; its removal is the design.
10. **b** - constructivism demands more deliberate teaching, not less: site, materials, scaffold, and its removal.

RRQ model answers and mark schemes

Award marks for the substance below, not for matching wording.

1. Learning as change in observable behaviour (1); classical conditioning (association) and operant conditioning (consequences), with any apt example of each (1).
2. Footsteps: neutral stimulus turned conditioned stimulus (1); scolding: unconditioned stimulus; falling silent: response; the pairing: the repeated bell-before-food arrangement (1 for the remaining three correctly placed).
3. A consequence is what actually follows; an unkept promise is a broken signal (1); it teaches pupils that the teacher's words can be ignored (1).
4. Reinforcement makes behaviour more frequent (positive: adds wanted; negative: removes disliked); punishment makes it less (1 for the full distinction); any apt negative reinforcement example, e.g. seatwork finished and the scolding stops (1).
5. Assimilation: new experience filed into an existing schema; accommodation: the schema rebuilt to fit what would not go in (1); any accurate original example (1).
6. Enactive, iconic, symbolic (1); a lesson placed in that order, or the missing mode named with its place (1).
7. The reinforcement was vicarious: pupils watched the outcome of answering wrongly (help, not shame) and adjusted without being addressed (2).
8. Any two of: importance, similarity, warm relationship (1); the teacher is present daily and central, so is a model in every interaction whether or not they accept it (1).
9. The zone is the gap between independent and assisted performance (1); Babar's three levels: sums alone (behind the zone), sums with the hint (in it), the whole worksheet unaided even with help (beyond it) (1).

10. Behaviourist: refusing work earns attention - re-aim attention (1); cognitive: the worksheet meets a missing schema - find and supply the step (1); social learning: trying visibly costs standing - change what trying is seen to earn; constructivist: the task is beyond even assisted reach - a nearer task plus a scaffold (1 for the remaining two).

ERQ rubrics

Each ERQ is marked out of 20 using the analytic scheme below.

ERQ 1 - the star chart, precisely

Criterion	Marks
The actual reinforcement is named precisely, not as failure or cheating	5
The redesign states exact behaviour, exact check, trained outcome (<i>Analyze</i>)	7
One honest risk of the redesign is named	4
Plain, accurate, organised writing within the word count	4

ERQ 2 - two poems

Criterion	Marks
The difference is explained in schema terms, not effort or ability	6
Each teacher's next step follows from the analysis and is doable (<i>Analyze</i>)	6
The account honours what Rashid did learn (the operant training)	4
Plain, accurate, organised writing within the word count	4

ERQ 3 - the first wrong answer

Criterion	Marks
The mechanism is explained with the observational-learning steps and vicarious reinforcement	6
The "consequential act" claim is argued, not asserted (<i>Analyze</i>)	6
What should be made observable is specific and realistic	4
Plain, accurate, organised writing within the word count	4

ERQ 4 - ninety seconds

Criterion	Marks
The zone is located with Babar's actual task levels	5
The scaffold is identified and its temporariness shown as the design (<i>Analyze</i>)	7
The account explains why a better explanation was not the remedy	4
Plain, accurate, organised writing within the word count	4

ERQ 5 - four lenses, one pupil

Criterion	Marks
All four lenses are applied accurately, each with its response	6
The first choice is justified with evidence from Amjad's description (<i>Analyze</i>)	6
The switch condition is observable, and the chosen lens's blind spot conceded	4
Plain, accurate, organised writing within the word count	4

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